

PROJECT II - Game Planning

THE UNKNOWN

A 3D First-Person Action-Adventure Game

- An action-adventure game with a third-person perspective.
- Immersive exploration in a semi-open world
- Combat-driven gameplay with focus on Taoist philosophy
- A narrative journey that involves choice and self-discovery



A young Taoist priest who embarks on a fantastic journey to follow the guidance of the Lord. On his journey, he explores unknown areas, defeats enemies, collects items and remnants of souls, befriends various people and beasts, and gradually unravels the secrets hidden underneath the beliefs initiated by the Lord. Learn about the mission, make choices, and ultimately, rule your destiny...

Role: Game Planner and Designer

INSPIRATION

INVESTIGATION AND RESEARCH

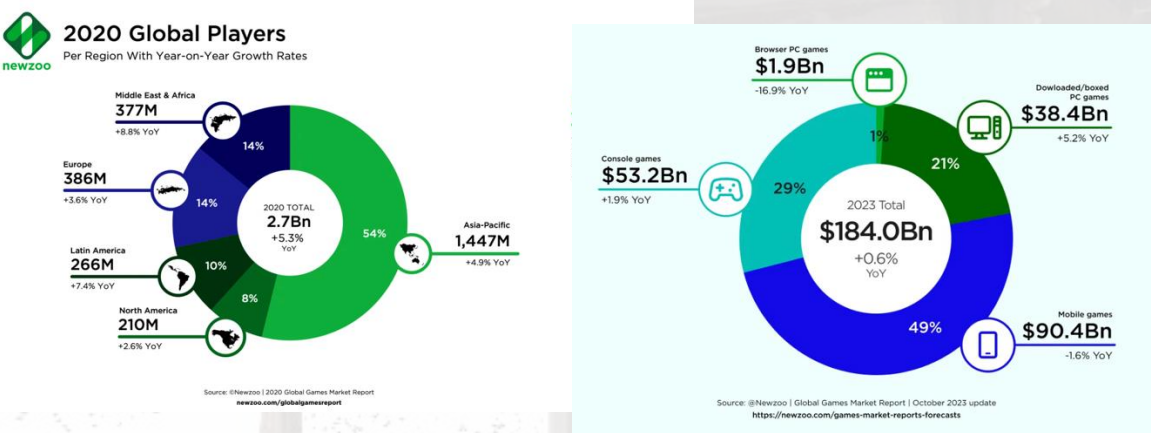
INTERVIEW

The Unknown was inspired by my interest in Chinese Taoist culture and traditional mystical themes. During my research into Taoist philosophy and belief systems, I was deeply inspired by the theme of “searching for oneself” and “searching for the truth”. In addition, many players are interested in stories with cultural depth and philosophical thinking, which gave me the idea to incorporate these elements into the game. Combined with the demand for high quality content in the current game market, I hope that through The Unknown, I can present a world that has the flavor of oriental culture, but is also full of fantasy and adventure, allowing players to think about the relationship between faith and self-mission in the process of exploring the unknown.



Hence my research and statistics related to games and data for this type of title. When conducting pre-market research for the program, it was intuitively important to understand the interests and preferences of the target players.

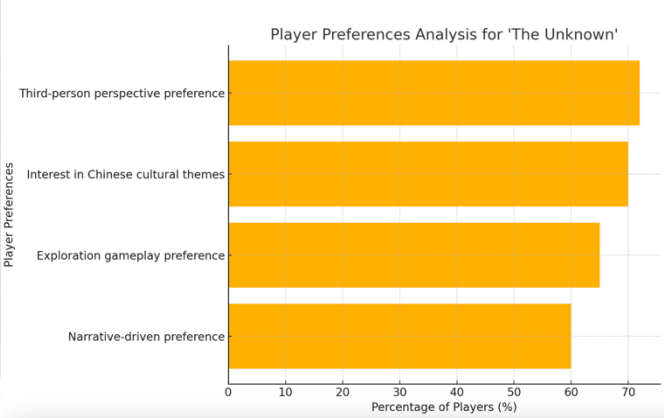
According to Newzoo's Global Gaming Market Report 2023, action-adventure games accounted for about 20% of the global gaming market, and this is expected to grow to 25% by 2025. Meanwhile, after the release of Black Myth: Wukong & 2024 on August 20, it quickly topped the Steam playlist, with total sales of more than 4.5 million points on the first day and total sales of more than 1.5 billion yuan, which inspired a huge feverish pillow of traditional Chinese culture among overseas players.



According to the above two pictures, it can be seen that the Asian market occupies an important position in the global game market. This shows that games with more Chinese cultural elements not only attract Asian players, but also enhance players' sense of immersion and immersion through cultural resonance. At the same time, single-player games and PC games also account for a sizable share of the overall game market. These data provided strong support for the initial direction of the game plan, and clarified the strategic positioning of developing for single-player and PC platforms with Chinese culture as the core.

The debut of Black Myth Wukong also inspired me to want to design a game rich in Chinese cultural elements. According to Digital Arts, overseas games incorporate Chinese elements in a variety of ways, including the restoration of visual elements of the national style, the creation of Chinese characters, thematic borrowing and re-narrating, as well as spiritual constructs, demonstrating players' demand for exploratory and narrative-driven gameplay.

I interviewed ten of my friends who play games around me and ran a tally of favorite preferences for game genres.



The results show that the interviewees showed high interest in action-adventure games with a third-person perspective, which they believe enhances the immersion of the game and the realism of character interactions. Meanwhile, 70% of players expressed strong interest in games with Chinese culture and mystery themes, believing that these elements can bring unique cultural experiences and deep narratives. In addition, 65% of players prefer exploratory gameplay, especially the discovery of hidden areas and story clues, suggesting that the game needs to provide rich exploratory content to fulfill players' desire for adventure. In contrast, 60% of players emphasized the importance of narrative-driven gameplay, where they look for a compelling story to drive the experience. This data provides a clear basis for the game design direction of The Unknown, suggesting that a game strategy that incorporates Chinese culture and emphasizes exploration and narrative can better meet players' needs.

RANK	PRICE	CHANGE	WEEKS
1	Prepurchase \$59.99	▲ 5	10
2	Free To Play	▼ 1	627
3	Free To Play		386
4	\$349.00		129
5	Free To Play	▲ 4	5

PLAY TYPE ANALYSIS

Deep Storytelling

The third-person perspective allows the player to explore the entire game world from a more enlightened viewpoint. This perspective combines the player's external and internal observations of the character and allows them to empathize with the protagonist while exploring the outside world. In comparing the two, the third-person perspective is better suited for this game, as The Unknown is heavy on telling a deep story and showing complex character development.

Exploration and Discovery

Semi-open world games are designed to allow players to explore larger, more expansive maps at their own pace. In the case of The Unknown, allowing players to explore freely allows them to feel immersed and gradually explore the fascination and map design of Chinese mythology and Eastern religions.

Cultural and Aesthetic Display

Referring to the Black Myth Goku's interpretation of oriental aesthetics, the integration of dark style art design, third-person perspective and semi-open world gameplay all provide a good platform to showcase the unique visual style and cultural elements. In this way, players can gain a deeper understanding of Eastern culture and feel the more immersive atmosphere brought about by different scenarios during the exploration process.

Versatility in gameplay

The single-player mode provides players with a fully customized gameplay experience, allowing them to make choices through their own interests and preferences, selecting the game's combat styles, influencing the choices made under each story, and changing the ending. Likewise, this allows the game to incorporate more gameplay types, such as combat, puzzle solving, exploration and role-playing to satisfy the needs of different players. Since The Unknown focuses on role-playing and storytelling, the immersion is better enhanced by having the player's choices affect the ending.

Game Overview and Basic Setting

Game Objective

Explore the game world by controlling the protagonist, completing quests along the way, making choices and guiding the character to the path you wish to take.

Core Game Play

1. **Exploration of an Unknown World:** Players will traverse an expansive, open-world environment filled with hidden secrets, puzzles, and lore to uncover.
2. **Action-Packed Combat:** A dynamic combat system combines melee attacks and ranged spellcasting, allowing players to engage enemies with strategy and skill.
3. **Collection and Progression:** By gathering items, soul fragments, and artifacts, players can unlock new abilities and enhance their character's power.
4. **Choices and Multiple Endings:** Players will face pivotal decisions that shape the storyline, leading to different outcomes and unique endings.

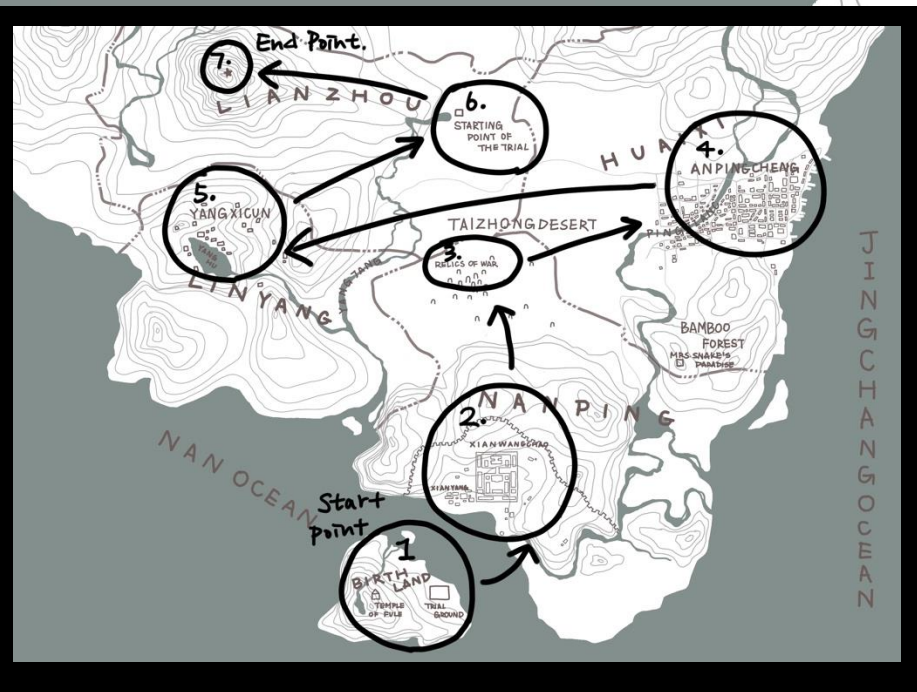
Unique Feature

1. **Cultural Depth:** The game integrates Taoist philosophy, talismans, and mythical creatures from Chinese folklore into a modern fantasy setting, creating a one-of-a-kind world.
2. **Dynamic Morality System:** Player choices impact not only the story's ending but also the game world and character relationships, enhancing the sense of immersion.
3. **Immersive Narrative:** Through environmental storytelling, detailed character development, and a rich, layered plot, players will delve into a world full of mystery and philosophical depth.

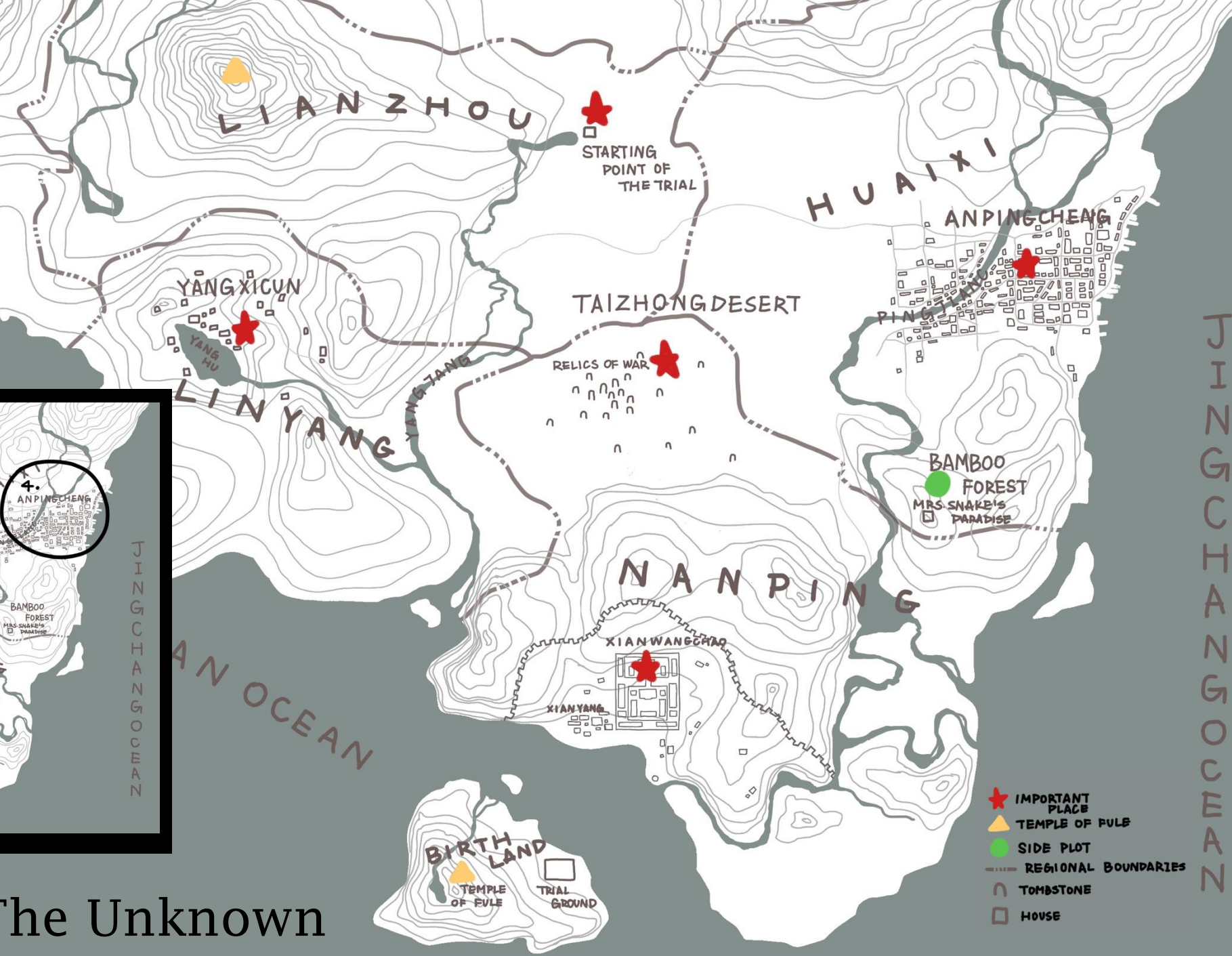
Emotional Experience for Players

1. **Curiosity and Excitement:** As players explore new areas and uncover hidden truths, they will experience the thrill of discovery.
2. **Tension and Achievement:** Overcoming powerful enemies and solving intricate puzzles will bring moments of intense challenge and satisfying victories.
3. **Emotional Resonance:** Through interactions with characters and the exploration of themes like faith and identity, players will embark on a journey of hope, struggle, and self-realization.
4. **Philosophical Reflection:** The game's narrative and choice mechanics will encourage players to ponder their sense of purpose and the nature of their destiny.

Game Flow



The Map of the The Unknown



Game Structure

The Unknown is a narrative-driven game that progresses through its compelling storyline. The game is structured into 7 distinct chapters, each designed to advance the plot and deepen the player’s understanding of the world and its characters.

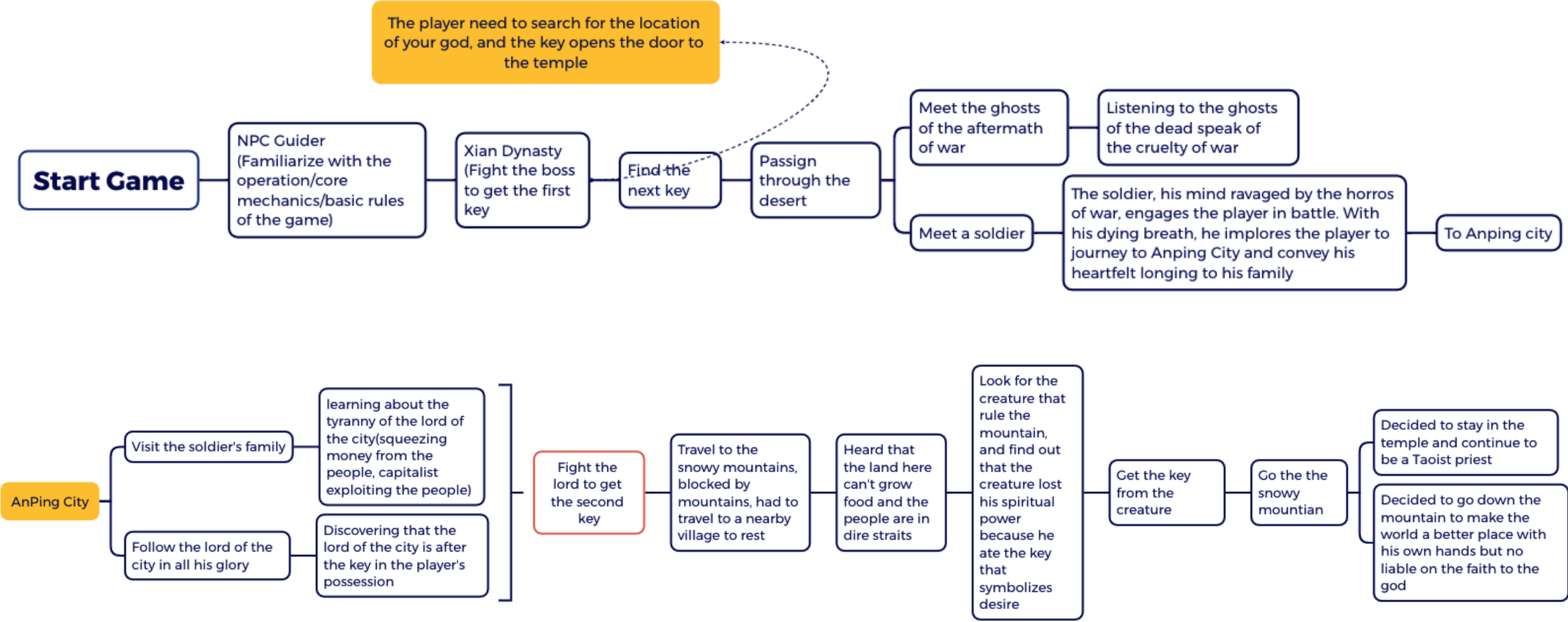
Main Story Flow: A young Taoist priest with his own beliefs has been living in a temple since he was born, believing that the Lord of his faith will bring happiness and peace to the living world. One day, the Lord, who has always connected with him, suddenly disappears, leaving only a line of “go down the mountain.” Snow Mountain is the only piece of information indicating a place where the Lord can be contacted. To get to the snowy mountain, three keys are needed. To find the keys to the snowy mountain to open the trial, the little Taoist embarked on a journey to find the keys. In the exploration process, the player controls the young Taoist to see the pain and disaster of life and the complex emotions between different characters. This makes the Taoist doubt his faith in the Lord, and he slowly finds himself under the characters' emotional ties and the story's advancement.

RoadMap Design: The entire route is linear, and the journey is guided indirectly through signposts, map design, visual guides, and conversations with NPCs toward the next area. As well as direct guidance, such as inaccessible areas, cliffs, monsters, and other obstacles to prevent the player from advancing to the next level.



The story between each area is interlocked, and the connection between the stories can be an excellent way to push the game forward. Designed as a linear play route with a semi-open map, it allows players to explore the map freely and simultaneously experience the whole game without losing their destination and abandoning the game in the middle of the game.

Game Flow



Character Design

The Main Character: Player

A Taoist priest who has great trust in the gods he serves to bring goodness to the living world. However, when he comes down from the mountain and learns about the world and the cruelty of reality, he realizes that the world is not as beautiful and peaceful as he imagined.



Other NPCs



The Guider

A character of consciousness that can change form at any time will be a guide throughout the game. When the player is lost and doesn't know how to move forward in the storyline, a messenger who calls himself the Lord will take the form of different creatures, such as a dove, a human, a deer, etc. to provide the player with direction and guidance.

He helps familiarize the player with the operating system and combat system, briefly describes the background of the story, and provides a brief description of the world setting.



The Monk



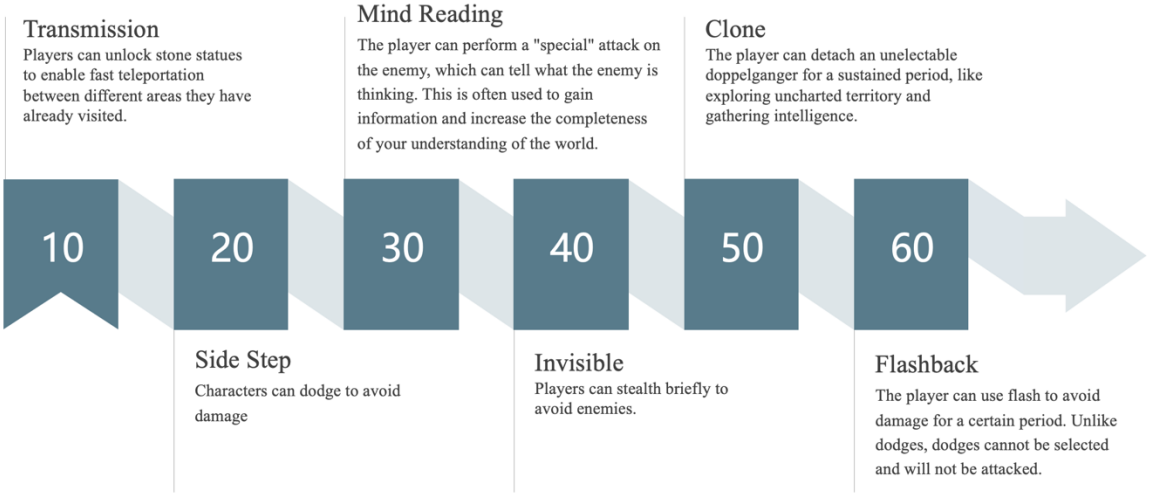
The Traveler

A traveler who travels around the world. Each time he appears, he will give the protagonist directions to a particular area, naming how to get to that location for the player.

CORE MECHANICS DESIGN

Growth and Development

Players can upgrade by fighting enemies, reaching certain game progress, and gaining experience points when they achieve certain achievements. Each upgrade gains new abilities.



Combat Mechanism

Spells and Physic Attack

This game can be reached by adding points to enable players to customize their preferred gameplay combat style. I designed the attack damage into two types: spell and physical. Spell damage corresponds to the release of spells, which can be performed to consume enemies in a large area or attack from a distance, but each release of spells requires the consumption of a mana bar. Physical damage, on the other hand, does not consume mana but needs to be close to the enemy to cause damage; the player's proficiency is higher. Players can choose through their preferences to create a combat style that suits them better.

Weakness Attack

Each enemy has a corresponding attribute weakness. For example, hairy enemies may be more afraid of flame damage. Fighting enemies by discovering their weaknesses can enhance the combat experience. It can also increase the player's enjoyment when fighting enemies.

Non-Turn-Based Combat

I designed it to be a non-turn-based battle style, allowing the player to counterattack by figuring out the enemy's attack patterns and finding the intervals between attacks while battling the enemy. Besides, players can dodge at the right time to avoid damage or to counterattack, making the combat process more engaging for the player. At the same time, there are higher requirements for the player's operation level. This combat style allows the player to feel a stronger sense of accomplishment after defeating a powerful enemy.

Stealth

The game can be achieved by hiding behind cover and briefly avoiding enemies. It is usually a countermeasure for eavesdropping enemy intelligence or infiltrating a place. At the same time, attacking an enemy from behind can inflict more damage, allowing the player to take care of enemies from behind without facing them head-on. This type of combat can take care of players more interested in experiencing the game's story rather than the combat aspect.

Point Adding System

The game's character growth comes mainly from the point system. Every time you fight, you will gain a certain amount of experience value, and a certain amount of experience value will be turned into points for the player to choose the ability value that he/she would like to enhance in a limited way. Combining the add-on systems of different listed games, I've summarized the six most important ability values that I think can be designed into this game.

Power

Increases the damage of physical output. For example, a general attack, the damage made by using a sword technique.

Faith

Increases damage when casting magic.

Weight Limit

Increases the weight cap on the amount of defense a player can wear, allowing the player to carry heavier armor. The heavier the defense can withstand higher damage.

Health Point (HP)

Increases the player's blood cap, making the player less likely to die.

Magic Point(MP)

Increases the player's Magic Point, allowing the player to unleash more spells at once.

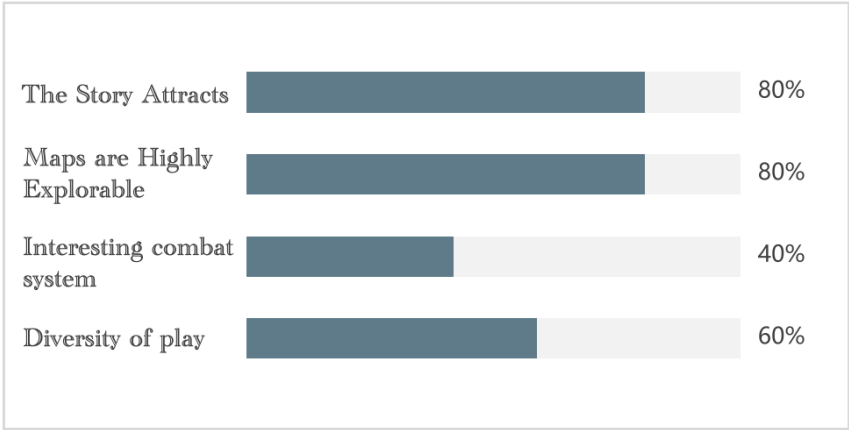
Response Rate

Allowing players to use dodge to avoid damage faster when facing enemies.



GAME TEST

I gave a brief introduction and explanation of the game process to five friends of different ages with different game preferences, simulated the flow of the game, and summarized the evaluation of the game and where the game stood out more and where it needed to be improved through the feedback they gave.



Tester 1 - The overall playability of the game is still high while having a highly explorable map and sucking in a compelling story is a plus. Because then we can feel and explore the entire storyline at our own pace of play. Adding more spinoffs and collectibles to the map would have been more enriching so players could explore the map with more content.

Tester 2 - I like that you can customize the combat yourself. I prefer to fight by observing the enemy's position by making pummel attacks and dodging rather than releasing spells. This gives me a higher sense of accomplishment after defeating strong enemies.

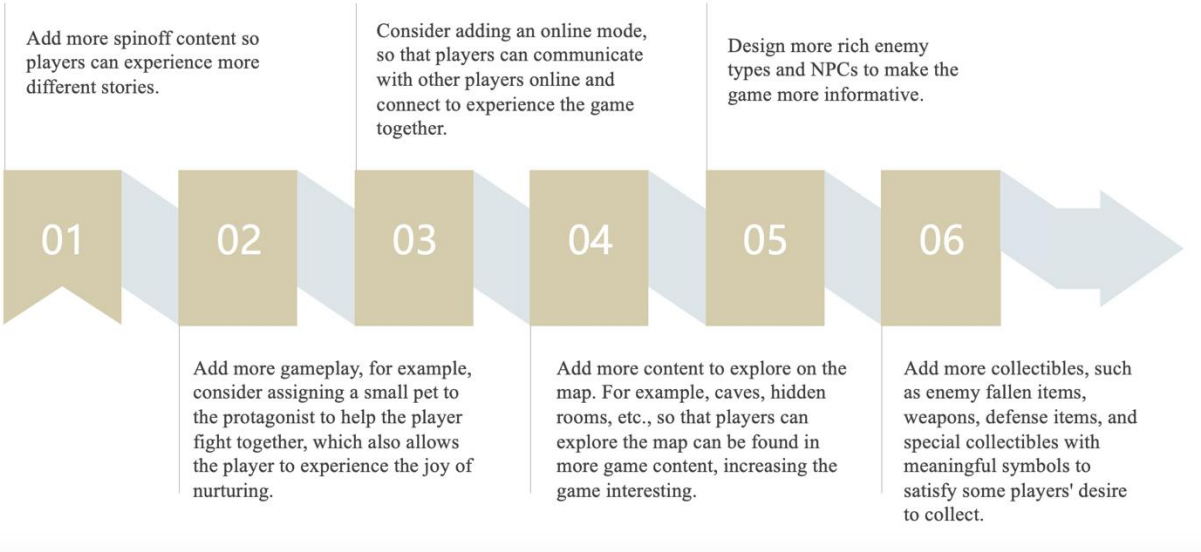
Tester 3 - I like to play games in the nurturing department. I love watching the character I'm controlling get stronger and stronger and gain new skills with each upgrade. It keeps me looking forward to the rest of the game.

Tester 4 - The story is so engaging! I like the idea of influencing the game's ending with my choices. The story allowed me to think better about my actual self; I felt like I wasn't manipulating a game character but observing myself and recognizing my values better.

Tester 5 - It would be nice to be in more N PC's and spinoffs. The story content is thin right now.

IMPROVEMENT

- 1. Player Agency and Replayability:** Although the game offers multiple endings based on player choices, incorporating more branching paths within each chapter could deepen player agency.
- 2. Dynamic World Interaction:** Introducing more interactive environmental elements could make exploration more engaging. For example, players could manipulate objects, solve environmental puzzles, or trigger hidden events based on their actions.
- 3. Combat System Diversification:** While the current combat system combines martial arts and mystical abilities, adding a skill tree or customization options for combat styles could enhance strategic depth.
- 4. Enhanced Tutorial Integration:** The tutorial chapter could be more seamlessly integrated into the narrative. Instead of a standalone prologue, the tutorial elements could be woven into the first main chapter, allowing players to learn mechanics organically as they progress through the story.
- 5. Expanded Side Content:** Adding optional side quests or character-specific storylines could enrich the main narrative and provide players with additional opportunities to explore the game's lore and world. These side stories could also offer unique rewards, further incentivizing exploration.



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